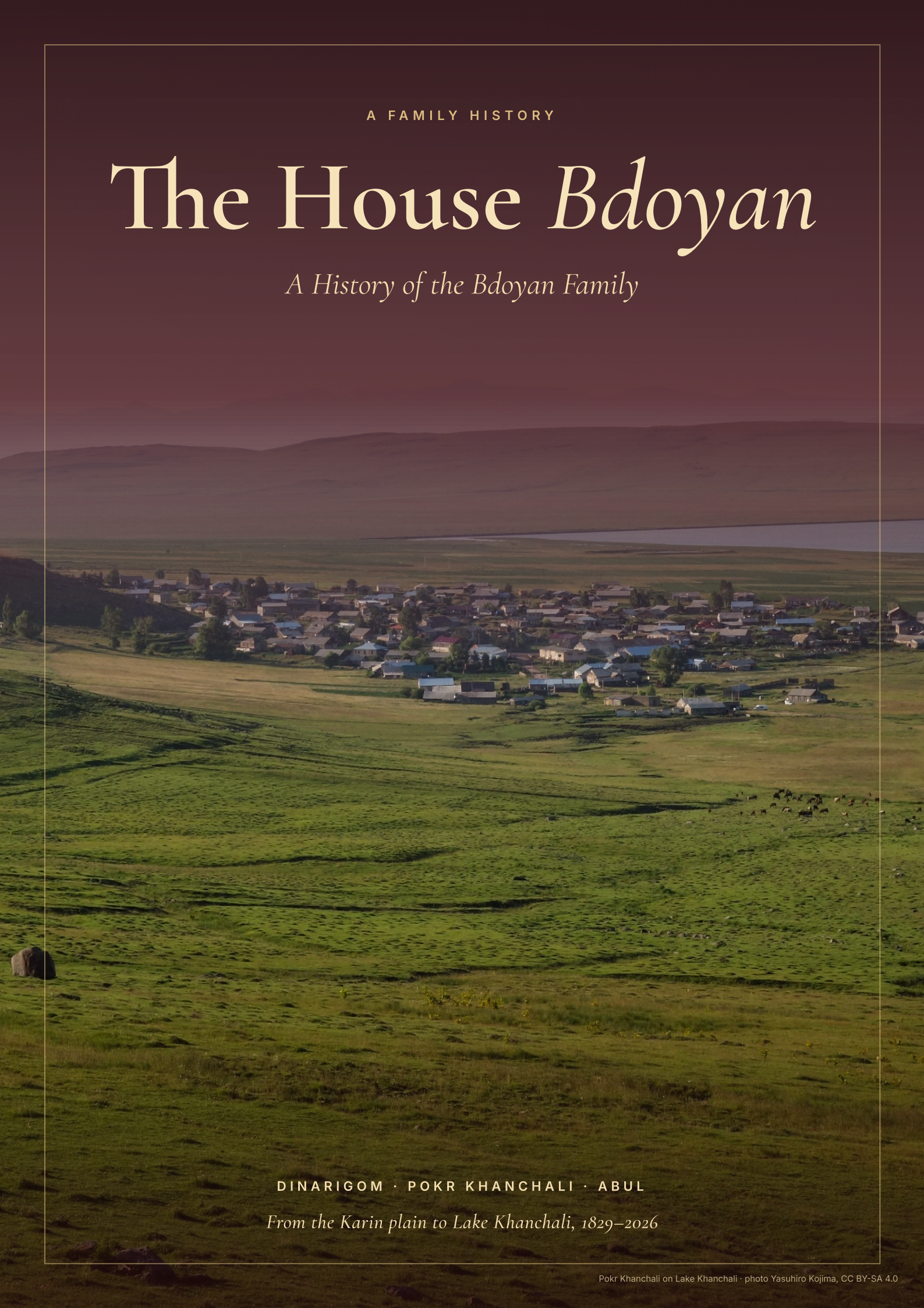
A FAMILY HISTORY

The House *Bdoyan*

A History of the Bdoyan Family



DINARIGOM · POKR KHANCHALI · ABUL

From the Karin plain to Lake Khanchali, 1829–2026

Pokr Khanchali on Lake Khanchali · photo Yasuhiro Kojima, CC BY-SA 4.0

A FAMILY HISTORY

The House *Bdoyan*

A History of the Bdoyan Family

From Dinarigom on the plain of Karin
to Pokr Khanchali on Lake Khanchali

by Harutyun Bdoyan

Working edition · October 2026

THIS EDITION

Working edition, October 2026. This book will be revised as new records are found; corrections and additions from the family are welcome. A companion volume, *Finding the Bdoyans: A Research Handbook*, lists every archive, library and online source and gives step-by-step instructions for completing the family tree. The online edition, with working links and a Contribute section where every Bdoyan can add a branch, a story or a correction, is at claude.ai/artifact/FcnSZy3zKiXexgTckt51aL.

HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Each fact is tied to its source by a small number that leads to the Notes at the end of the book. Where it matters how sure a statement is, it carries a mark:

● confirmed by a record ◐ probable, inferred from the records

○ family tradition or an estimate

The founder is called **Bdo (Bedros)**. Bdo is the name the family remembers; Bedros, the Western Armenian form of Petros, is his probable baptismal name and still has to be confirmed by a record (Chapter I).

SPELLING

Armenian names are written in a simple English form based on Eastern Armenian pronunciation (Bdoyan, Khanchali, Yesoyan); Western forms such as Bedros are given where they matter. Authors keep the spelling used in their own publications (Karapetian). The names of people and places in Georgian and Russian script are listed on the page “Names in three scripts”.

PICTURES

Cover photograph: “Patara Khanchali” by Yasuhiro Kojima, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0; cropped and overlaid with the title, and this cover adaptation is likewise shared under CC BY-SA 4.0. Lake Khanchali panorama: Yasuhiro Kojima, CC BY-SA 4.0. Old Erzurum: Brian Dell, public domain. Winter on Lake Khanchali: Paata Vardanashvili, CC BY-SA 4.0. Abuli fortress: Aleksey Muhranoff, CC BY-SA 3.0. Akhalkalaki: Dor Shabashewitz, CC BY-SA 4.0. All from Wikimedia Commons, cropped. Maps drawn for this book from Natural Earth data (public domain); diagrams and charts drawn for this book.

SOURCES AND TRANSLATIONS

Short quotations from published works are given for research and family use, with their sources. Translations from Armenian are our own. Research and drafting were done with the help of Claude, an AI model made by Anthropic; readings of Armenian texts should be checked by an Armenian reader before they are relied on.

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This is the story of one household that became a family name. It begins with a man called Bdo (Bedros) on the high plain of Karin, follows his descendants across a closing frontier in 1829–1830 to Lake Khanchali, and gathers every Bdoyan the records name, from his time to ours.

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The story in ten facts, and how sure each one is

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AT A GLANCE

c. 1740–1780
Bdo (Bedros) born; head of a household on the Karin plain (estimate)

1828–1829
Russo-Turkish war; Russian army takes Kars, Akhalkalaki, Akhaltsikhe and, in 1829, Erzurum

14 Sept 1829
Treaty of Adrianople hands Karin back to the Ottomans

1829–1830
Mass exodus from Karin; Bdo's descendants help settle Pokr Khanchali

1830s
Bdoyents Papo, patriarch of the village's Bdoyans, builds its first mill

1850s · 1865 · 1875
Village church first recorded; parish school at work; St Hakob rebuilt in stone

4 March 1910
Vard Harutyuni Bdoyan born in Pokr Khanchali

1938–1986
Vard Bdoyan's career as an ethnographer in Yerevan; his Javakhk book appears in 2014

20th–21st c.
Branches in Yerevan, Kharkiv, the Rostov region and beyond; about 1,440 Bdoyans today

At a glance KEY FINDINGS

The Story in Ten Facts

- ● The Bdoyans of **Pokr Khanchali** descend from families who came from **Dinarigom**, a village 15 km north of Erzurum (Karin), in 1829–1830.
- ○ The family's founder was **Bdo**, head of a great household in Dinarigom, born around 1740–1780.
- ◐ "Bdo" was a pet name. His baptismal name was most likely **Bedros (Petros)**; a register entry is still needed to prove it.
- ● They left with the great exodus that followed the Treaty of Adrianople of 1829, led by Archbishop Karapet Bagratuni.
- ● In the 1830s the Bdoyans' patriarch in Pokr Khanchali, **Bdoyents Papo**, built the village's first water-mill.
- ● In the 1910s the family lived wall to wall in **five adjoining houses**: those of Harutyun, Grigor, Anton and Davit, Mesrop and Zakar.
- ● The ethnographer **Vard Harutyuni Bdoyan** (1910–1986) was born in Pokr Khanchali; his life's work on Javakhk was published in 2014 and names many of his relatives.
- ● A second line lived in **Abul**: Hakob Bdoyan came there from Umudum, near Dinarigom, in 1830. ○ That it shares Bdo as founder is the family's view, still to be proven.
- ○ About **1,440 Bdoyans** live today, almost all in Georgia, Armenia and Russia (an estimate).
- ● The church registers of Pokr Khanchali survive in the National Archives of Armenia and on FamilySearch microfilm 1915055 and 1915180 — the next place to look for Bdo's real name.

● confirmed by a record ◐ probable ○ family tradition or estimate. Sources for each fact are in the chapters and their notes.



“They acquired not only single houses, but whole quarters.”

VARD BDOYAN, ON THE SETTLERS OF 1830

Chapter I THE FOUNDER

Bdo of the Karin Plain

Every Armenian surname is a small history. *Bdoyan* is the name of one man's household, carried for more than two centuries across two empires and three modern countries.

The story begins on the plain of **Karin** — today's Erzurum in eastern Turkey. It is a broad, almost treeless upland at close to 1,900 metres, ringed by mountains and drained by the headwaters of the Euphrates. For centuries it was the heart of *Bardzr Hayk*, "High Armenia", and its fields were worked from Armenian farming villages; at the start of the nineteenth century there were roughly a hundred of them on the plain alone.[2]



KARIN TODAY — A street in the old town of Erzurum, with the twin minarets of the thirteenth-century Çifte Minareli madrasa and the Palandöken mountains behind. Photo: Brian Dell, public domain.

Family tradition places the home of **Bdo (Bedros)** in one of these villages: **Dinarigom** ○, and the records now bear out that the family came from there ●. Samvel Karapetian's survey of Javakhk, built on the church archives, states that the people of Pokr Khanchali descend from Armenians who

THE NAME

Bdo + -yan = Bdoyan

The Armenian ending *-yan* (older *-ean*) means "of" or "belonging to the line of". **Bdoyan** therefore simply means *"of Bdo's family"*. In village speech the household was also called by the collective form *Bdoyents* — "Bdo's people".[1]

moved there from Dinarigom village, Karin district, in 1829–1830, and places Dinarigom on the right bank of the Euphrates, **15 km north of Karin city**; its Turkish name today is Myratgeldi.[3] The village also appears, spelled Dinargom, in the 1909 list of the forty-eight Armenian villages of the Karin district — so the Armenians who stayed behind in 1829 went on living there for another eighty years.[4]

Who was Bdo?

No document yet found carries his name, and nothing written in his own hand survives. What we can say comes from the name itself and from how Armenian village society worked.

One thing is almost certain: **Bdo was not the name he was baptised with.** Armenian priests christened children with the names of saints and of the Bible — Petros, Hakob, Grigor, Baghdasar — and no one was baptised "Bdo". In daily life, though, villagers called each other by short pet forms ending in *-o*, and the notes Vard Bdoyan took in Pokr Khanchali are full of them: Papo, Khnko, Gevo for Gevorg.[5] Bdo is one of these.

The likeliest full name is **Petros** (Peter) — in the Western Armenian pronunciation of Karin, **Bedros** ◐. Hrachia Acharyan's great *Dictionary of Armenian Personal Names* gives *Peto* and *Petik* as the usual pet forms of Petros.[6] The Karin dialect belongs to the Western Armenian family, in which Petros is pronounced *Bedros* — so Peto sounded like *Bedo*.[7] Written in the Eastern Armenian spelling used in the Caucasus, that sound is written with just three letters, B-D-O: Armenian script does not write the short vowel *ə* after a first consonant, and the name is said "Bə-do". A Western Armenian family from Bitlis, the Bedoyans, likewise remember that their surname grew out of Bedrosian.[8]



Baghdasar has also been suggested, but a pet form of Baghdasar would normally keep its *gh*, which Bdo lacks. Only a register naming one of his sons as "son of Petros" — or of some other name — can settle it, and that is one of the first

things the family is now looking for. Until then this book calls him **Bdo (Bedros)**. Pet names like this were how neighbours actually spoke, and they often outlived the formal name.

More telling is that his name, rather than his father's or his son's, became the family's for good. In the villages of the Armenian Highlands a family line was usually called after the head of household whose authority and number of descendants made that house stand out, and in Javakhk each kin quarter was named after the eldest of its clan.[9] When the household divided, each branch still answered to that founder's name. That Bdo became such a name-giver tells us he was the respected **tanuter**, the master of the house, of a large and lasting family.

DATING BDO

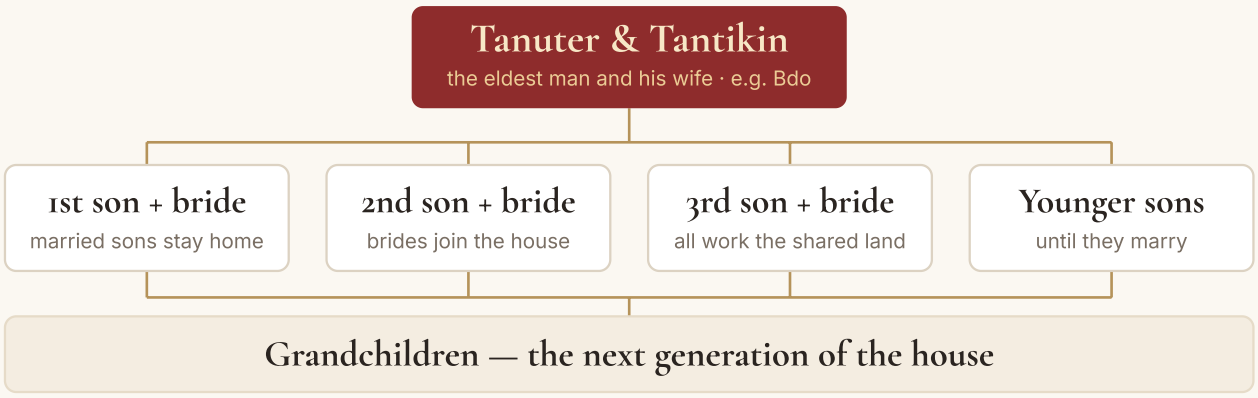
Vard Bdoyan was born in 1910, son of Harutyun. At about 28–32 years per generation, counting back five or six steps from Vard places Bdo's birth somewhere around **1740–1780** ○. His sons and grandsons were the generation that made the journey of 1829–1830.

Life in a patriarchal household

Bdo's family would have lived as a **gerdastan**: married sons stayed under their father's roof with their wives and children, so that three or four generations, often several dozen people, shared one hearth, one store of grain and one set of fields. Authority ran from the eldest man down; daughters married out into other houses, and brides came in.[10]

HOW A GERDASTAN WORKED

One roof, one hearth, three or four generations



SHARED
one hearth (tonir), one granary, one purse, common fields and flocks

MOVEMENT
daughters marry out to other houses; brides marry in from other villages

WHEN IT DIVIDED
every branch kept the founder's name: "Bdo's people", the Bdoyans

This is not guesswork borrowed from elsewhere. It is the way of life that Bdo's own descendant, the ethnographer **Vard Bdoyan**, spent his career describing (see Chapter IV). He showed that such great households survived across the Armenian Highlands right up to the late nineteenth and early

twentieth centuries, and that the villages themselves were built in clustered quarters of joined houses — the physical shape of clan loyalty and of communities that had to defend themselves.[11]

Dinarigom gives us a living picture of such a house. In 1959 Vard Bdoyan wrote down the memories of a man from that very village whose father's household had held thirty-three people.[12] His description of a Dinarigom house speaks of the same scale: one long building with four *gomasenyak* — the raised winter rooms built inside the cattle barn, where the family spent the cold months beside its animals.[13]

On the Karin plain that life meant spring ploughing with heavy wooden ploughs drawn by teams of oxen, wheat and barley harvested in a short summer, flocks taken to the uplands, and long winters when people and animals sheltered in the same half-sunken stone buildings for warmth.[14] It was a hard, close-knit and self-reliant world. In 1828 it was overtaken by war.

WORDS OF THE HOUSEHOLD

gerdastan
the large patriarchal family of several generations under one roof

tanuter
master of the house; senior male head

tantikin
mistress of the house; she ran stores, kitchen and daughters-in-law

yot port
"seven navels" — the seven generations of ancestors one was expected to know

A VOICE FROM DINARIGOM

In July 1959 Vard Bdoyan interviewed Simon Davtyan (formerly Kopalyan), a man from Dinarigom who had settled in Leninakan (Gyumri). Simon told him that his father's household had numbered **33 people**, with **five cradles** rocking in the house at the same time.

Chapter II THE JOURNEY

The Great Exodus, 1829–1830

Between the end of 1829 and the summer of 1830, tens of thousands of Armenians left the Karin plain behind. Among them were the sons and grandsons of Bdo (Bedros).

In the Russo-Turkish War of 1828–1829 the Russian Caucasus army under General Ivan Paskevich swept into the Ottoman borderlands. Kars fell in the summer of 1828, and on 24 July Paskevich stormed Akhalkalaki, followed by Akhaltsikhe; in the summer of 1829 the army entered Erzurum itself.[3] For the Armenians of Karin, who had welcomed and supplied the Russian troops, it seemed that Christian rule had arrived to stay.

It had not. By the **Treaty of Adrianople**, signed on 14 September 1829 (2 September in the Old Style calendar used in Russia), Russia kept the districts of Akhalkalaki and Akhaltsikhe — the region Armenians call **Javakhk** — but handed Erzurum, Kars and Bayazet back to the Sultan.[4] Fearing reprisals, and encouraged by the Russian authorities who wanted settlers for their new frontier lands, the Armenians of the province chose to leave with the withdrawing army.

The emigration was led by the Armenian prelate of Erzurum, **Archbishop Karapet Bagratuni** (1779–1856), and it used a right written into the treaty itself: Article 13 allowed the inhabitants of the returned lands to move freely to the other empire. The Ardahan villages left at the end of 1829; the people of Erzurum, Basen and Khnus followed in the summer of 1830.[5] Whole villages packed what they could onto ox-carts — grain, tools, bedding, livestock, the vestments and books of their churches — and moved north-east in columns over the mountain roads toward Kars and the new Russian frontier. In Javakhk the heavy two-wheeled carts of Karin stayed in use for decades.[6]

IN NUMBERS

75,000–80,000
Armenians estimated to have left Erzurum province with the Russian army, most of them from Karin itself.[1]

58,000
from Erzurum, Basen, Khnus and Derjan settled in the Akhaltsikhe and Akhalkalaki districts, by historian Ashot Melkonyan's count.

≈ 50
villages founded or rebuilt by them in the Akhalkalaki district alone, where only 1,716 Armenian families had remained in 1829.[2]

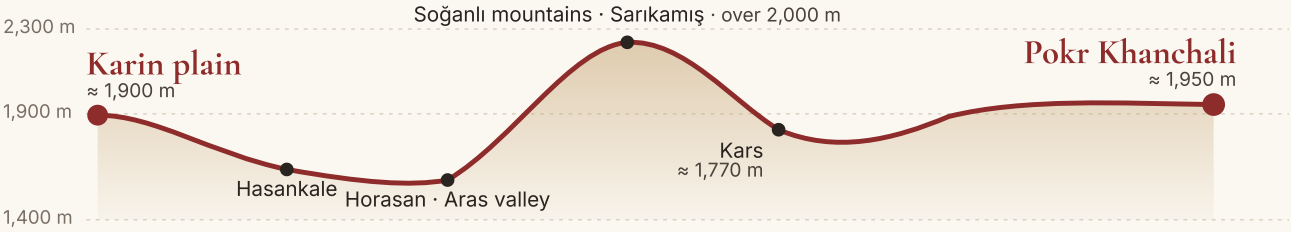
For the people of Dinarigom and their neighbours, the road led to the high, half-empty plateau of Javakheti, around the lakes of Khanchali and Paravani. Decades of border warfare had left much of it thinly settled, and the Russian administration directed the newcomers there to farm it.[7] The villages of the Karin plain scattered across that plateau side by side: Dinarigom's families founded Pokr Khanchali; people from **Umudum**, which lay at almost the same distance north of the city (16 km), settled **Abul** and **Majadia**; those of Hindzk went first to Sazel near Akhaltsikhe and then to Mets Khanchali, across the lake from Pokr Khanchali.[8]

Vard Bdoyan describes how they did it. By old custom, he writes, the Armenians resettled by forming *kin quarters*: "they acquired not only single houses but whole quarters", and it was thought unacceptable for a kinsman to build apart from the rest of his clan.[9] A family that had lived as one quarter in Karin rebuilt itself as one quarter in Javakhk.

The move was not just a change of country. Karin and Javakheti lie at almost the same height — about 1,900 metres against the 1,930–1,980 metres of Pokr Khanchali[10] — with the same short summers, deep snows and open, windswept fields. The migrants brought their ploughs, seed, customs and dialect, and much of that life could be lived again on the new plateau. That continuity is one reason the families of Javakhk kept their Karin identity so strongly, and why the Karin dialect is still spoken there today.[11]

SAME HEIGHT, SAME LIFE

The road from one high plain to another

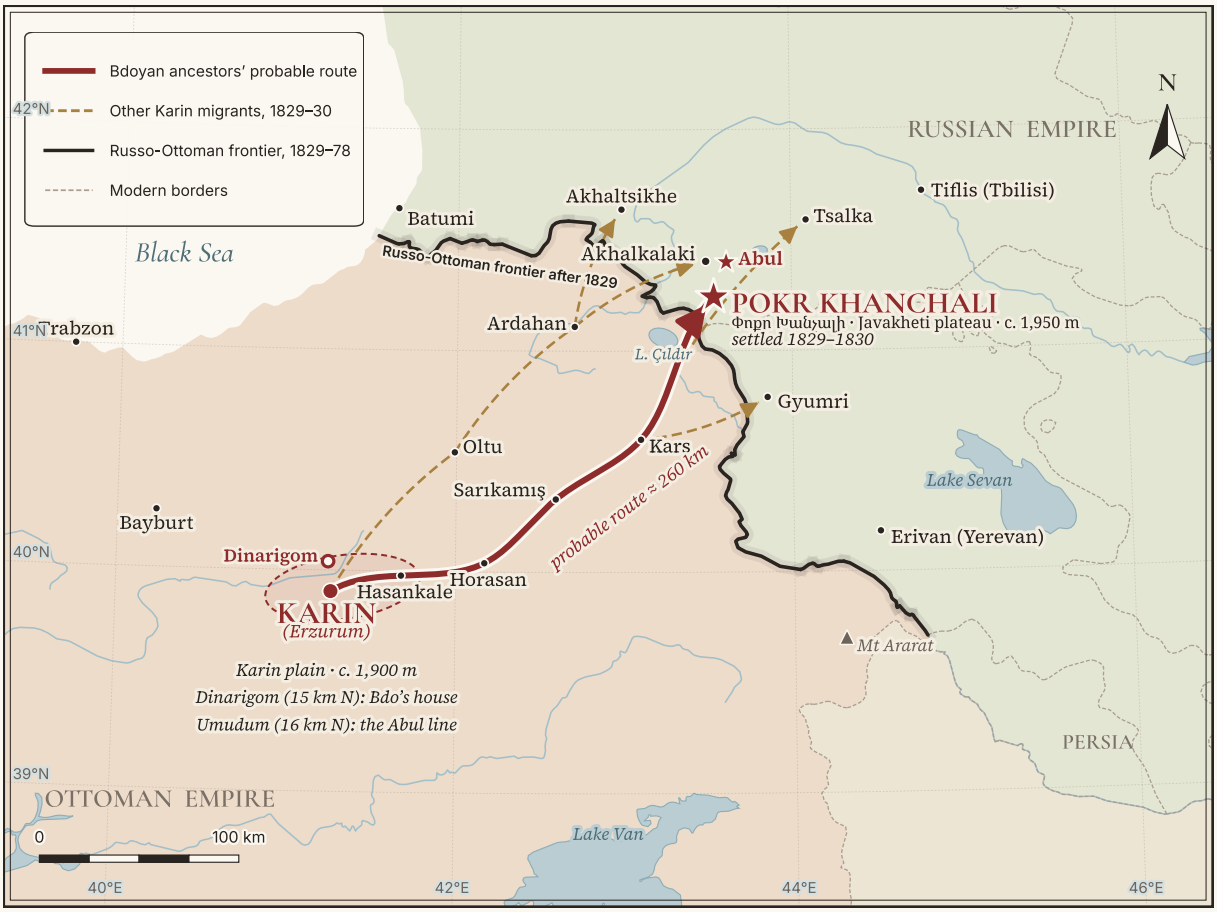


Schematic profile along the probable route · heights approximate · distances not to scale

Village to village

Karapetian's survey records, for many Javakhk villages, the exact Karin village their founders came from.[12] Taken together they show the plain north of Karin re-forming itself on the Javakheti plateau, one community at a time.

FROM THE KARIN DISTRICT, 1829–30	TO JAVAKHK	NOTES
Dinarigom · 15 km north of Karin	**Pokr Khanchali**	The Bdoyans' village; St Hakob church
Umudum · 16 km north of Karin	**Abul** · Majadia	Hakob Bdoyan came to Abul in 1830; 29 Umudum families founded Majadia
Hindzk	Mets Khanchali	By way of Sazel, near Akhaltsikhe
Khotorjur and Kan	Pokr Gyondura	
Gaghtarij	Alatuman	
Ortiz	Burnashet	15 families moved on to Tsalka in 1844
Yerkan Mansur	Korkh	Some later founded Nor Korkh in Tsalka
Snkarij	Kulikam	



MAP 1 The exodus from Karin, 1829–1830. The red line shows the most probable route taken by the family, via Kars to the shore of Lake Khanchali — about 260 km in straight stages and considerably more on the mountain roads. Gold lines show other destinations of Karin migrants. Red stars mark Pokr Khanchali and Abul, the two Bdoyan villages of Javakhk; the open circle marks Dinarigom. The frontier is drawn approximately; it held until Russia annexed Kars and Ardahan in 1878.

Chapter III THE VILLAGE

A New Home on Lake Khanchali

III

On the southern shore of a shallow upland lake, the migrants from Karin founded the village that would be the Bdoyans' home for the next two centuries: Pokr Khanchali.



LAKE KHANCHALI

The shallow lake on the Javakheti plateau, about 1,930 metres above sea level; Pokr Khanchali lies on its southern shore. Photo: Yasuhiro Kojima, CC BY-SA 4.0.

Pokr Khanchali — "Little Khanchali", to distinguish it from its larger neighbour Mets Khanchali across the lake — stretches along the southern shore of Lake Khanchali, within 200 metres of the water, on the Javakheti volcanic plateau in today's Georgia, close to the Armenian border. Its people, Samvel Karapetian writes, descend from the families who came from Dinarigom in 1829–1830 ●, and it has been an Armenian village ever since. For a time it had a few Turkish neighbours as well: a document of 1870 counts eight houses of Tarakama Turks (96 people), there were six in 1884, and in 1918 they left for Turkey.[1]

The Bdoyan quarter

We can see exactly where the Bdoyans lived. In 1950 Vard Bdoyan climbed the rocky hill called Kurch above the village and sketched it house by house, leaving out everything new,

so as to record Pokr Khanchali as it had stood in the 1910s. The village was divided into an upper and a lower half, *veri mayla* and *tsatsi mayla*, and each half into groups of joined houses, every group the quarter of one or more related families. The old Armenian word for such a quarter, *tagh*, Vard notes, had already been forgotten in Karin: the settlers called it a *mahla*, and named it after the eldest of the clan.[3]

The Bdoyans held one block of **five adjoining houses** at the end of the first group of the lower quarter, beside the Vardanyans and the Yesoyans: the houses of **Harutyun**, **Grigor**, **Anton and Davit**, **Mesrop** and **Zakar Bdoyan** ●.[4] It is the kin quarter in its plainest form — the descendants of one house still living wall to wall eighty years after the migration.

Bdoyents Papo and the first mill

Vard also preserved the name of the family's leader in the new village. In the 1830s, he writes, the first water-mill of Pokr Khanchali was built by **Bdoyents Papo** — "Papo of the Bdoyans" — the *nahapet*, or patriarch, of the Bdoyans of the village ●. Water was scarce on the slope of the hill called Atorik where he built it, so it turned only one millstone, but it went on working long after him. When it had come down to Papo's great-grandsons, the Ayvazyans built a handier mill closer to the village, and a village song teased the Bdoyans about their old one. In 1918 raiders wrecked both mills, and the villagers had to take their grain to the mills of Dilif.[6]

Papo is the earliest Bdoyan known by name. As head of the family in the first years after 1830, he belonged to the generation of Bdo's sons or grandsons ◐; his great-grandsons were most likely the men of Vard's sketch ◑. "Papo" is itself a pet name, so his baptismal name is still to be found.

POKR KHANCHALI TODAY

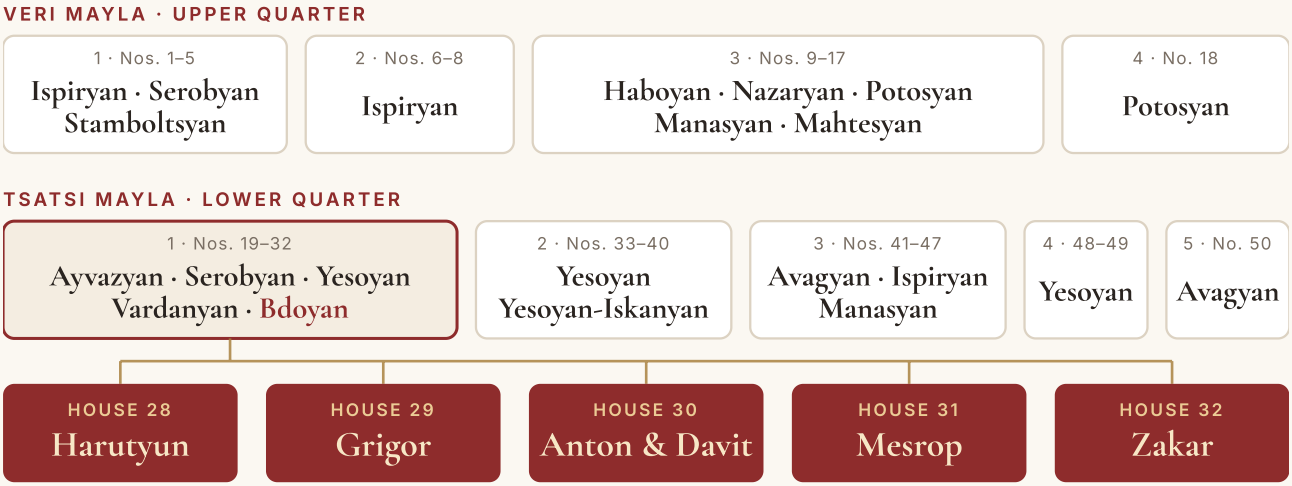
Name: "Little Khanchali"
Georgian: პატარა ხანჩალი (Patara Khanchali)
Country: Georgia, Samtskhe-Javakheti region, Ninotsminda municipality
Location: 5.5 km south-west of Ninotsminda (formerly Bogdanovka)
Altitude: 1,930–1,980 m
Sister village: Mets (Didi) Khanchali, on the same lake
Settled: 1829–1830, from Dinarigom, Karin
Population: 554 (2014 census)[2]

THE BDOYAN HAY TEAM

Haymaking was done by teams called *hampa*, formed by kinship and kept almost unchanged for decades: the Ispirents, Avagents, **Bdoyents**, Davitents, Yesoyents and Vardanents teams, among others. Each team cut the first letter of its leader's surname into its haystacks with a spade, so that the Armenian letter **B** followed by **30** meant "Bdoyan, 30 haycocks".[5]

POKR KHANCHALI IN THE 1910s

The village by kin quarters, after Vard Bdoyan's 1950 sketch



The five Bdoyan houses, wall to wall at the end of the first lower group

Also listed: two houses outside the village, the church (1875), the school and the spring · schematic, not a map

Counting the village

Every year the diocese asked each parish how many souls it had, so the village can be followed almost year by year. The 78 people of 1853 had become 147, in thirteen houses, by 1866, and 691 by 1914.[7] Then came catastrophe. In 1918 the Ottoman army overran Javakhk; the villagers fled, and hunger and disease followed the refugees. By 1921 only 353 people were left.[8] Anush Bdoyan's husband, **Mesrop Bdoyan** — very probably the owner of house 31 ◐ — fell fighting in the Dilif pass in May 1918, and his brother Khnko was killed in the village in January 1919.[9] Pokr Khanchali recovered to 593 people by 1926 and to 801, in 215 houses, by 1987. In the Second World War 113 of its people went to the front, and 58 did not come back.[10] The 2014 census counted 554 inhabitants, 99% of them Armenian.[11]

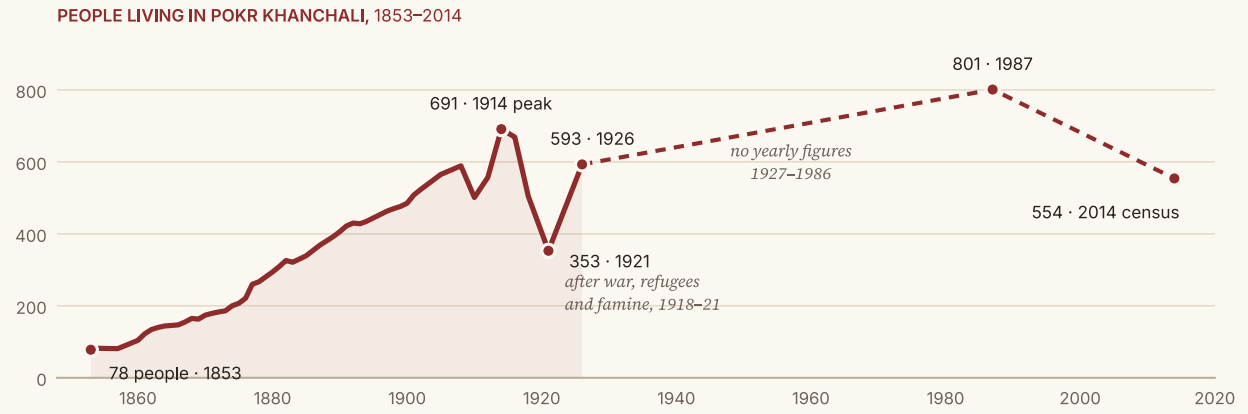


CHART Yearly counts, 1853–1926, mostly from the files of the Armenian diocese of Georgia (National Archives of Armenia, fond 53) and other archive collections, as tabulated by Karapetian; 1987 from the village council registers; 2014 from the Georgian census. Dashed lines join points with no yearly figures between them.

The church of St Hakob

A village of Karin Armenians was organised around its church. **Surb Hakob** (St James) is mentioned as early as the 1850s, and in the 1860s it was still a modest wooden building.[12] In 1875 the villagers rebuilt it, with finely dressed stone on the west front and hewn stone on the other walls. It is a hall of 16.8 × 10.3 metres with walls 90 cm thick; inside, two pairs of round columns carry the double-pitched roof. The only door is in the west wall, and the font, cut from a single block of stone, is set into the north wall.[13] A parish school was already working in 1865, with one teacher and ten pupils.[14]

Two inscriptions record the rebuilding. The one on and around the tympanum over the door says, in our translation, that in the days of Catholicos Gevorg the church of Pokr Khanchali “was built and dedicated to Saint Hakob” and blessed by Archbishop Grigor Sakinyan of Akhaltsikhe; its worn last lines include the name of **Father Vardan**. The second, carved south of the door, says that the church was consecrated “through the efforts and the honest earnings of my dear people” on the feast of the Holy Cross of Varag, **28 September 1875**.[15]

The records also name people who served it. **Father Vardan Movsisyan** was one of its priests from the 1860s to the 1880s — very probably the Father Vardan of the inscription ◐, and the man most likely to have written down the baptisms, weddings and burials of the Bdoyans in those decades.[16] Karapet

Khoperyants taught in the parish school in 1875, and at the start of the twentieth century the church held a capital of 257 roubles 69 kopeks in silver.[17] Around the church lies a cemetery with gravestones of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, and the village also keeps a memorial to the fedayi commander Gevorg Chavush (1870/71–1907).[18]

That church matters to anyone tracing the family. For almost ninety years, from the 1830s to the Soviet period, its priests wrote down every baptism, marriage and burial in the village. Those registers are the most direct written trail from today's Bdoyans back to the families who arrived in 1830; the companion research handbook shows where they are kept. The gravestones around the church are a second record, carved in stone.

The surname becomes official

In Karin, people were known by their own name, their father's name and their house. Under Russian rule the authorities began to list every household, its head and his sons in registers, censuses and family lists. Over the course of the nineteenth century the old house-names hardened into fixed surnames written on every document. That is how "Bdo's people" became, permanently and officially, the **Bdoyan** family.

The names themselves were older than the records. Summing up Vard Bdoyan's findings, the editor of his Javakhk book, Rafayel Gharibyan, notes that a kin quarter was usually called after the head of the clan, and that **almost every clan that moved to Javakhk kept the name it had borne in Karin before the migration.**[21] The Russian clerks wrote down names that the families had brought with them.

ST HAKOB, STEP BY STEP

- ☐ **1850s** — first mention of the church
- ☐ **1860s** — still a wooden church
- ☐ **1865** — parish school: one teacher, ten pupils
- ☐ **1860s–80s** — Fr Vardan Movsisyan serves
- ☐ **1875** — rebuilt in stone; consecrated 28 September
- ☐ **Soviet era** — closed and left to decay
- ☐ **2015** — major restoration
- ☐ **Today** — services held again

THE DISTRICT IN NUMBERS

1893 — the Akhalkalaki district has 102 villages and about 60,000 people.[19]

1897 — the first Russian census counts 72,709 people in the district; 72% give Armenian as their mother tongue.[20]



WINTER ON THE PLATEAU

Lake Khanchali frozen in February, with the snow-covered Abul mountains behind. Winters at almost 2,000 metres are long and hard, as they were on the Karin plain the families had left. Photo: Paata Vardanashvili, CC BY-SA 4.0.

A dialect carried from Karin

The settlers brought their speech with them. The **Karin (Karno) dialect**, once spoken from Kars to Baberd with Erzurum at its centre, survives today in Shirak and in Javakhk — in Akhalkalaki, Ninotsminda and their villages.[23] When older people in Pokr Khanchali speak the village tongue, they are still using the words of the Karin plain that Bdo knew.

Life in Pokr Khanchali followed the rhythm the families had known in Karin: grain and potatoes on the high fields, cattle and sheep, long winters, and the gerdastan household slowly giving way, by the early twentieth century, to smaller families. Into one of those families, in 1910, was born the man who would become the Bdoyans' best-known son.

A FEW KARIN WORDS

ekhtyar — old man, elder

ton — rain

chit — neck

entuen — from here

tori — until

22

Chapter IV THE SCHOLAR

Vard Bdoyan, the Family's Scholar

1910	1986	14	200+
born 4 March in Pokr Khanchali, to a farming family	died 19 February in Yerevan; his Javakhk book followed in 2014	monographs published or prepared, and 50+ articles	printer's sheets of field notes gathered across Armenia and Georgia

The best-known Bdoyan is the ethnographer and folklorist Vard Harutyuni Bdoyan — a son of Pokr Khanchali who spent his life recording exactly the kind of village world his ancestor Bdo (Bedros) had lived in.[1]

Vard Bdoyan was born on **4 March 1910** in Pokr Khanchali, into a farming family. He went to school in the village, finished the pedagogical college in Akhalkalaki in 1932 and taught in secondary schools from 1933 to 1937 before settling in Yerevan, where he completed the Pedagogical Institute by correspondence in 1943.[2]

1938	Begins collecting folklore for the Armenian branch of the USSR Academy of Sciences
1939–44	Librarian and manuscript specialist at the Matenadaran
1944–59	Researcher, then head (from 1949) of the ethnography department of the State History Museum of Armenia
1948	Defends his candidate dissertation under Professor Stepan Lisitsyan
1959	Senior researcher at the new Institute of Archaeology and Ethnography, where he worked for the rest of his life
1964–72	Teaches Armenian ethnography at Yerevan State University
1969	Doctoral dissertation: *Agricultural Culture in Armenia*; Doctor of Historical Sciences from 1970
1986	Dies in Yerevan on 19 February[4]

He never lost touch with home: in 1961 he gave some 300 objects to the regional museum of Akhalkalaki, and he argued in print that Javakhk deserved a museum of its own.[5]

What Vard Bdoyan said

Vard Bdoyan's ideas speak directly to the Bdoyan story. Here are six of them, drawn from his published work as summarised by the ethnographer Rafik Nahapetyan on his centenary in 2010, and from his Javakhk book.[6]

MAJOR WORKS

1. *The Cult of Land and Child Fertility among Armenians* — thesis 1948, part published 1950
2. *Armenian Folk Games*, three volumes (1963–1983)[3]
3. *Agricultural Culture in Armenia* (1972)
4. *Armenian Ethnography: A Brief Outline* (1974) — long the only university textbook of the subject
5. *Armenian Salt-Cellars* (1986)
6. *The Ethnography and Folk Art of the Armenians of Javakhk* (2014, after his death)

READ HIM ONLINE

His Javakhk book is a free PDF in the Pan-Armenian Digital Library; see the research handbook for this and his other works.

ON ANCESTORS

"There is no people whose later art of dress is not directly connected with the art of its ancestors."

His conviction that the present is always tied to the ancestors runs through all his work. He traced each region's costume back to the ancient peoples of the Armenian Highlands and rejected the claim that Armenian dress was simply borrowed from neighbours.

ON THE GREAT HOUSEHOLD

The gerdastan lasted for centuries

He traced the patriarchal great family to the rise of the father-centred clan, and showed how it survived through the feudal centuries before breaking up only in the late 19th and early 20th centuries — the very world Bdo's family lived in.

ON KINSHIP WORDS

Native words for "kin"

He held that the words for a blood-kin group, *aryunaru* and *tsegh*, are native Armenian, while *azg* and *tohm* came from Pahlavi and Persian. Through these terms he followed the links between the wider clan and the family line.

ON THE VILLAGE

Houses built for kin and defence

The Armenian village of attached quarters and joined houses, which lasted into the 20th century, was in his view the product of two forces: clan tradition on one side and communities defending themselves under hostile rulers on the other.

ON HIDDEN MEMORY

Old beliefs survive in disguise

His "theory of disguise" held that ancient beliefs did not vanish with Christianity but lived on in hidden forms. The female-shaped clay salt-cellars of Armenian homes, he argued, still carried the image of the old goddess Anahit, protector of mother and child.

ON RESETTLING AS KIN

"They acquired not only single houses, but whole quarters."

Writing of the 1830s in Javakhk, he showed that the settlers from Karin rebuilt their villages clan by clan, and that a kinsman who built far from his clan's quarter was frowned upon. Each quarter was named after the clan's eldest — which is how "Bdo's people" could carry his name from the Karin plain to Lake Khanchali.

The book that came out after him

For years it seemed that his most important work for the family would never appear. His archive held about 130 printer's sheets ready for print, including two large studies of his homeland, *The Ethnography of Javakhk* and *The Folklore of Javakhk*; some 20 sheets of the folklore went to the Hayastan publishing house in 1986, the year he died, and were never printed there.[7] Years later an editor handed the folklore manuscript — more than five hundred large pages, saved, as he puts it, by sheer chance from being burned — to the folklorist **Rafayel Gharibyan**, himself from Javakhk. Gharibyan traced the family and returned it; they entrusted him with the ethnography manuscript as well, and he spent years turning both into one book.[8]

It appeared in 2014 from Yerevan State University Press, with support from the Gulbenkian Foundation: *The Ethnography and Folk Art of the Armenians of Javakhk*, 752 pages, compiled, introduced and annotated by Gharibyan, with drawings by Vard himself.[9] It is the source of the village sketch, the mill of Bdoyents Papo and the Dinarigom household in this book. It

does not mention Bdo by name: the link to Dinarigom comes from the church archives quoted by Karapetian, and the founder's name from the family.

The family in his notebooks

Vard Bdoyan began collecting at home. His very first recordings, in 1938, were made from an old storyteller and from "his relative" Gevorg Bdoyan of Akhalkalaki; in the summer of 1940 he worked in Pokr Khanchali itself, and among his best storytellers his editor names **Varvare**, **Anush** and **Balasan Bdoyan**. His notes on each of them, with birthplaces and dates, read like the first pages of a family register (see the box).[11]

Varvare Bdoyan, who married Harutyun Bdoyan of Pokr Khanchali in 1887, was a skilled dairywoman and potter who knew many proverbs. Vard was "son of Harutyun" and was born in 1910, and house 28 in his sketch is Harutyun's, so she was very probably his mother ◐ — though the notes never say so, and a register will have to confirm it.[12] **Anush** lost her husband Mesrop in the fighting of 1918, his brother in 1919 and both her sons, Grigor and Zavik, in 1941–1942; she turned her grief into verses that Vard wrote down and kept with deep respect.[13]

BDOYANS IN VARD'S NOTES

Varvare · b. 1870
born in Nardivan (Tsalka), married Harutyun Bdoyan of Pokr Khanchali in 1887

Anush "apla" · 1880–1953
born in Jigrashen, daughter of the teacher-poet Matevos; wife of Mesrop Bdoyan

Khachatur, son of Grigor · b. 1888
farmer and miller of Pokr Khanchali

Gevorg · b. 1890
of Akhalkalaki, son of the shoemaker Tadevos; "his relative"

Balasan · b. 1930
singer and dancer of Pokr Khanchali
10

Chapter V THE BLOODLINE

One Ancestor, One Family

THE CORE OF THE FAMILY STORY

Every Bdoyan is a descendant of Bdo (Bedros). The name itself is the record: Bdoyan means "of Bdo".

Common surnames like Grigoryan or Hakobyan arose independently in hundreds of places, from hundreds of unrelated men named Grigor or Hakob. Bdoyan is different.

1 **The name points to one man.**

Bdo was a nickname, most likely for Bedros (Petros). Countless men named Petros left sons who became Petrosyans; only in one known household did the nickname itself harden into the surname. Bdoyan is the name of one house, not a common pattern.

2 **One village, one house.**

The church archives confirm that Pokr Khanchali's families came from Dinarigom on the Karin plain, where, the family remembers, "Bdo's people" were a recognised house.[1]

3 **They moved together and stayed together.**

The family crossed the frontier as a group in 1829–1830 and put down roots in one village, Pokr Khanchali. There its patriarch, Bdoyents Papo, built the first mill, and eighty years later the Bdoyans still lived wall to wall as one kin quarter.[2]

4 **The name came from Karin.**

Clans that moved to Javakhk kept the names they had borne in Karin before 1829.[3] Bdoyans are few — about 1,400 people today, almost all in Georgia, Armenia and Russia[4] — and as far as is known, all trace their roots to Javakhk, and through it to the Karin plain.

So the Bdoyans are not simply people who share a name. They are one extended family, cousins of one another at greater or lesser distance, all descended in the male line from Bdo ○. His blood also runs in many families with other surnames, through the daughters of each generation who married into other houses.

The Bdoyans of Abul

Vard's notes also reveal a second Bdoyan line in Javakhk. In **Abul**, a village 10 km east of Akhalkalaki, lived the singer and church clerk **Smbat Bdoyan** (1887–1963), whose grandfather **Hakob Bdoyan** had come to Abul in 1830 from **Umudum**, a Karin village 16 km north of the city — almost exactly as far out as Dinarigom. The Abul singers Ruben and Sirun Bdoyan, whom Vard recorded in Yerevan in 1965, still sang songs that had come with their family from Umudum.[5]

The family's account and this record point the same way: back to one small stretch of the Karin plain north of the city. A great household there could easily have had a branch in a neighbouring village before 1829, through a son who took land or a brother who married into it, and in the family's view — that every Bdoyan descends from Bdo — Abul's Hakob was of Bdo's line too. This is the one link in the family story that a document or a DNA test still has to confirm ○; the research handbook shows how.

PROVING IT WITH DNA

Because a Y-chromosome passes almost unchanged from father to son, Bdoyan men from different branches should share Bdo's Y-DNA signature. The most telling test now is to compare a man of the Abul line with one from Pokr Khanchali: a match would join the two branches scientifically and would show Bdo's deep ancestral lineage in the Armenian Highlands.



ABOVE ABUL The ancient stone fortress on Mount Abul, above the village where Hakob Bdoyan settled in 1830. Photo: Aleksey Muhranoff, CC BY-SA 3.0.

About ten generations from Bdo

Counting about thirty years to a generation, a Bdoyan child born today stands nine or ten generations below the founder. The ladder below shows how those generations line up with history. Names other than Bdo, Papo, Harutyun and Vard are left for the family to fill in from records and memory; every name found so far is gathered in Chapter VI.

I	**Bdo (Bedros)** c. 1740–1780 · Karin	**The founder** ○ Known by the pet name Bdo; baptismal name most likely Bedros (Petros) ◐. Head of a great household in Dinarigom on the Karin plain.
II–III	Sons & grandsons born c. 1770–1820	**The migrants.** Leave Karin in 1829–1830 and help found Pokr Khanchali; their patriarch there, **Bdoyents Papo**, builds the village's first mill in the 1830s ●.
IV	First born in Javakhk c. 1830–1860	Raised under Russian rule; appear in the first registers and family lists.
V	Harutyun c. 1860–1890	**Vard Bdoyan's father** ●, who very probably married Varvare in 1887 ◐, and his kinsmen Grigor, Anton, Davit, Mesrop and Zakar — the five Bdoyan houses of the 1910s, most likely Papo's great-grandsons ◐.
VI	Vard b. 1910	**Vard Bdoyan** (1910–1986), the ethnographer ●, and his generation, including Khachatur son of Grigor (b. 1888) and Gevorg of Akhalkalaki (b. 1890).
VII–VIII	Soviet generations c. 1930–1980	Moves documented to Yerevan, Kharkiv, the Rostov region and the Altai.
IX–X	Today born c. 1980–2020s	About 1,400 living Bdoyans, almost all in Georgia, Armenia and Russia.

Generation dates are estimates. Vard Bdoyan's exact place in the line (fifth, sixth or seventh from Bdo) can only be fixed from the records listed in the research handbook. Marks: ● confirmed by records · ◖ probable · ○ family tradition or estimate.

Chapter VI THE FAMILY

The Bdoyans We Know

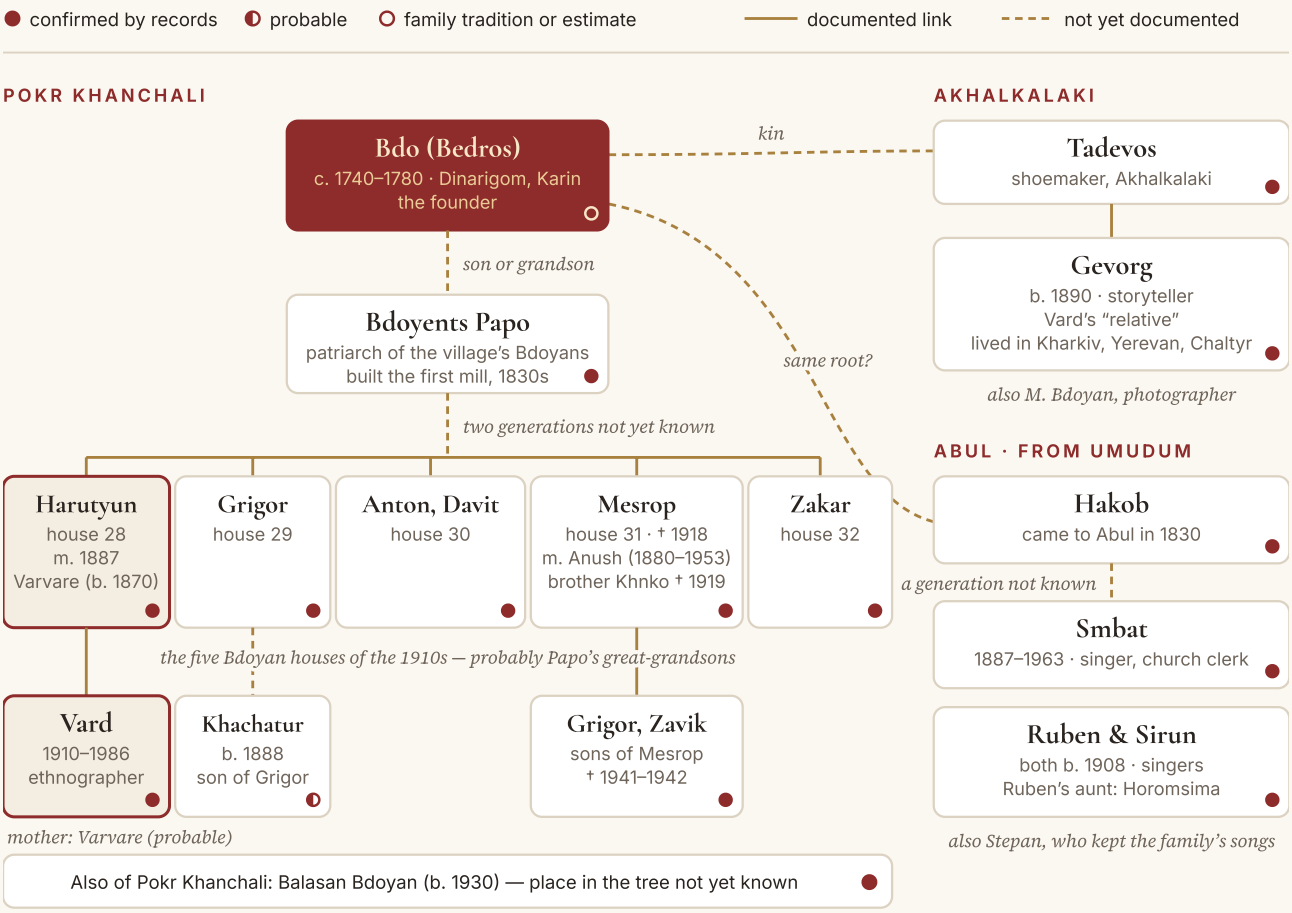
VI

Two centuries of the family can now be pinned to real people. This chapter gathers every Bdoyan named in the sources, shows how they connect, and marks how sure each link is.

Most of these names come from one place: the notes Vard Bdoyan wrote about the people who told him stories and sang him songs between 1938 and 1980, and the plan of Pokr Khanchali he drew in 1950.[1] Together they give three groups: the Bdoyans of Pokr Khanchali, a branch in the town of Akhalkalaki, and the Bdoyans of Abul, whose ancestor came from Umudum.

THE BDOYANS KNOWN SO FAR

Every Bdoyan named in the sources, and how they connect



Who's who

Every person in the chart, with what the sources say and where they say it. Page numbers refer to Vard Bdoyan's *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk* unless another source is named.

NAME	DATES	PLACES	WHAT WE KNOW	SOURCE
POKR KHANCHALI				
Bdo (Bedros) ○	c. 1740–1780	Dinarigom, Karin	Founder of the house; baptismal name probably Petros (Bedros) ◐	Family tradition; Ch. I
Bdoyents Papo ●	fl. 1830s	Pokr Khanchali	Patriarch of the village's Bdoyans; built its first water-mill	730
Harutyun ●	m. 1887	Pokr Khanchali, house 28	Husband of Varvare; father of Vard	151, 707, 747
Varvare ●	b. 1870	Born Nardivan (Tsalka); Ghulalis; Pokr Khanchali	Married Harutyun in 1887; dairywoman, potter, storyteller; very probably Vard's mother ◐	707
Vard Harutyuni ●	1910–1986	Pokr Khanchali; Yerevan	Ethnographer and folklorist (Chapter IV)	747; Nahapetyan
Grigor ●	—	Pokr Khanchali, house 29	Householder in the 1910s	151
Khachatur, son of Grigor ●	b. 1888	Pokr Khanchali; Mamzara; Akhaltsikhe	Farmer and miller; that his father was the Grigor of house 29 is likely ◐	711
Anton and Davit ●	—	Pokr Khanchali, house 30	Householders in the 1910s	151
Mesrop ●	† May 1918	Pokr Khanchali, house 31 ◐	Husband of Anush; killed fighting in the Dilif pass	151, 683
Anush, daughter of Matevos ●	1880–1953	Born Jigrashen; Pokr Khanchali	Wife of Mesrop; poet and storyteller	683, 707
Khnko ●	† Jan. 1919	Pokr Khanchali	Brother of Mesrop; killed in the village	683
Grigor and Zavik ●	† 1941–1942	—	Sons of Mesrop and Anush; died in the war years	683
Zakar ●	—	Pokr Khanchali, house 32	Householder in the 1910s	152
Balasan ●	b. 1930	Pokr Khanchali; Altai; Yerevan	Singer and dancer; parents not yet known	720
AKHALKALAKI				
Tadevos ●	—	Akhalkalaki	Shoemaker; father of Gevorg	707

NAME	DATES	PLACES	WHAT WE KNOW	SOURCE
Gevorg ●	b. 1890	Akhalkalaki; Kharkiv; Yerevan; Chaltyr (Rostov region)	Shoemaker and storyteller; Vard's "relative"	8, 707
M. Bdoyan ●	20th c.	Akhalkalaki	Photographer on Vard's field trips	28
ABUL, FROM UMUDUM				
Hakob ●	came 1830	Umudum (Karin) → Abul	Grandfather of Smbat	734
Stepan ●	19th c.	Abul	Moved to Abul; handed on the family's long song to Smbat and Horomsima	732
Smbat ●	1887–1963	Abul	Farmer, church clerk and singer	734
Horomsima Avagyan, born Bdoyan ●	—	Abul	Paternal aunt of Ruben	732
Ruben ●	b. 1908	Abul; Katnatu (1920s); Yerevan (1964)	Shepherd and singer	720
Sirun ●	b. 1908	Abul; Katnatu; Yerevan	Wife of Ruben; singer	720

What we still don't know

The chart has four gaps that matter more than any others. Each can be closed with the records listed in the research handbook.

1 **Bdo's baptismal name.**
Bedros (Petros) is probable but unproven. The earliest burial and baptism registers of Pokr Khanchali, and the first Russian household lists of the 1830s, may name him or his sons.

2 **Who Papo was.**
"Papo" is a pet name too. Was he Bdo's son or his grandson, and what was his full name?

3 **The two missing generations.**
Between Papo and the five householders of the 1910s lie two generations with no names yet. The parish registers of the 1840s–1880s should supply them; the first step can be the record of Harutyun's marriage in 1887, which should name his father.

4 **The Abul link.**
Were Hakob of Umudum and the Bdoyans of Dinarigom one family before 1829? A Y-DNA comparison between the two lines would answer it fastest.

Chapter VII THE FAMILY TODAY

Where the Bdoyans Live Today

VII

For a century after 1830 the family stayed rooted in two villages of Javakhk. In the twentieth century its members began to move — and today the Bdoyans are still, overwhelmingly, a family of Georgia, Armenia and Russia.

How many, and where

Surname-statistics services, which compile public registers and phone directories, estimate that about **1,440 people** bear the name Bdoyan today. Some 559 of them live in Georgia, 499 in Armenia and 374 in Russia; only a handful are recorded anywhere else — two in the United States, one each in Belgium, Bulgaria and Abkhazia.[1] These are estimates, not a count, but the proportions are clear: almost every Bdoyan still lives within a day's journey of Javakhk or in the Russian cities where Javakhk families have worked for generations.

BDOYANS BY COUNTRY TODAY · ESTIMATE, ABOUT 1,440 PEOPLE



CHART Estimated number of people named Bdoyan, by country. Source: surnam.es, compiled from public registers; small numbers are rounded by the source.

Moves the records show

Vard Bdoyan's notes on his storytellers record where several Bdoyans went in the twentieth century. They are the first documented branches of the family outside Javakhk (Map 2):[2]

- **Vard** left Pokr Khanchali for the college in Akhalkalaki and then for Yerevan, where he lived and worked from the late 1930s until his death in 1986.
- **Gevorg** of Akhalkalaki, a shoemaker born in 1890, lived in Kharkiv (now Ukraine), in Yerevan and in the village of Chaltyr, near Rostov-on-Don in southern Russia.
- **Khachatur**, born in Pokr Khanchali in 1888, lived there, in Mamzara and in Akhaltsikhe.
- **Balasan**, born in Pokr Khanchali in 1930, lived in the village, in the Altai in Siberia, and in Yerevan.
- **Ruben and Sirun** of Abul moved with their family to Katnatu, a new village of the Bogdanovka (Ninotsminda) district, in the 1920s, and to Yerevan in 1964.



AKHALKALAKI The town of Akhalkalaki today: home of the shoemaker Tadevos Bdoyan and his son Gevorg, and the town where Vard Bdoyan went to college. Photo: Dor Shabashewitz, CC BY-SA 4.0.

The wider pattern

These individual moves fit the paths taken by Javakhk Armenians in general. In the Soviet decades young people went to **Yerevan** to study and stayed for work. Others settled just across the border in **Gyumri** and the towns of Shirak, or

in **Tbilisi**, the capital of their own republic. From the 1960s many Javakhk men went to work seasonally in southern Russia, and whole families followed them; after 1991, economic collapse pushed a new wave to Russia's large cities.[3] This general picture (Map 3) is a guide to where branches of the family may be found ○; each family can mark its own.

The quickest way to complete this chapter is from the family itself. If each branch notes where its members live today, the picture of the family can rest on facts rather than estimates; the research handbook includes a sheet for collecting them.



MAP 2 Moves recorded in Vard Bdoyan's notes: from Pokr Khanchali and Akhalkalaki to Yerevan, Akhaltsikhe, Kharkiv and Chaltyr near Rostov-on-Don, and from Pokr Khanchali to the Altai. Dates are mostly unknown; most of these moves belong to the 1920s–1960s.



MAP 3 The heartland. Red stars: the two Bdoyan villages of 1830, Pokr Khanchali and Abul. Red circles: towns where Bdoyans are documented in the sources. Gold circles: places where Bdoyans very probably live, but which no source in this book names. The tinted oval marks the core of Javakhk.



His father's household numbered thirty-three people, and five cradles were rocking in the house at once.

A MAN OF DINARIGOM, REMEMBERING · 1959

Afterword HOW IT WAS POSSIBLE

How This History Could Be Written

Most Armenian families cannot follow one ancestor across two centuries and two empires. The Bdoyans can, for three reasons: the kind of name they carry, the work of one of their own, and the tools that have only recently put scattered records within reach.

1 · Bdoyan began as a clan name, not a surname

Before the nineteenth century Armenian villagers had no surnames in the modern sense. A man was known by his own name, his father's name and the name of his *tohm*, the lineage or house he belonged to. That house name, the *tohmanun*, was taken from a founding ancestor and passed down the male line: *Bdoyents*, "Bdo's people".[1] Only under Russian rule, when officials began to write every household into registers and lists, did these house names harden into fixed surnames.[2]

That history is what makes the Bdoyans traceable. A common surname such as Grigoryan was formed again and again from thousands of unrelated men called Grigor. A *tohmanun* names one house. Everyone born a Bdoyan therefore belongs, by the family's own rule, to the line of one man, and the name stayed attached to one kin quarter of one village long enough for the first registers to catch it there. It also explains why the name is so rare (about 1,440 people) and so concentrated in Javakhk and the places its people moved to.[3]

2 · The work of Vard Bdoyan

The second reason is that the family produced its own ethnographer. Vard Bdoyan spent half a century recording how the Armenians of Javakhk lived, and he began at home. His Javakhk book, published in 2014, gives what no register

does: the plan of Pokr Khanchali in the 1910s with the five Bdoyan houses side by side, the story of Bdoyents Papo and his mill, the custom by which the settlers of 1830 rebuilt whole kin quarters, and a note on every storyteller he recorded, with birth years, parents, marriages and moves.[4] Most of the names in Chapter VI come from those notes. Without them the family's story would begin with the first Soviet certificates.

His work also tells researchers where to go next. Every note cites a numbered field notebook, and his notes on where each family came from point to the right villages on the Karin plain, Umudum for the Abul line among them. The book that grew out of his archive is in effect the family's first research guide.

A WORD OF CAUTION

A house could also take in a son-in-law who came to live with his wife's family, or an adopted child, and give him its name. That is why the book marks the descent of every Bdoyan from Bdo as family tradition O until Y-DNA tests from several branches confirm it.

3 · New tools

The third reason is recent. Twenty years ago the sources for this book were scattered across reading rooms in Yerevan, Tbilisi and Istanbul. Today many of them are a search away:

- **Digital libraries.** Vard Bdoyan's 2014 book, Ashot Melkonyan's history of Javakhk and Rafik Nahapetyan's biography are free PDFs in the Pan-Armenian Digital Library; Samvel Karapetian's village survey is on the RAA website; Acharyan's dictionary of names is on the Internet Archive.
- **Archive catalogues online.** The parish index of the National Archives of Armenia, the FamilySearch microfilm catalogue and the metrical-book finder of the National Archives of Georgia show exactly which registers survive for Pokr Khanchali and where.
- **Open pictures and maps.** Photographs shared on Wikimedia Commons under open licences, and the public-domain map data of Natural Earth, made the illustrations possible without a photographer or a cartographer.
- **Surname statistics.** Services that compile public registers give a first estimate of how many Bdoyans live where.
- **Artificial intelligence.** An AI model, Claude, made by Anthropic, helped search these sources, read scanned Armenian books (including text in an old computer

encoding that no longer displays correctly), translate and compare passages, draw the maps and charts, and set the pages. It does not replace the archives or the family's memory: every fact in this book is tied to a source so that a person can check it.

None of these tools can read a register that has not yet been opened, or remember what only an elder remembers. The next chapter of this history will come, as the first one did, from the family itself.



The man christened Petros lived on as Bdo.

CHAPTER I

Reference WORDS TO KNOW

Words to Know

apla — "elder sister"; a respectful title for an older woman, as in Anush apla.

azg — a clan or extended family line; in Javakhk, the families of one kin quarter.

Bardzr Hayk — "High Armenia", the historic province around Karin (Erzurum).

-ents — "of the house of"; Bdoyents means "Bdo's people".

family lists (*posemeinye spiski*) — Russian household registers of 1886, naming every household head and his family.

fedayi — Armenian irregular fighter of the national movement, c. 1890–1915.

fond — an archive collection; references such as "fond 53, series 1, file 3848" point to one file in it.

gerdastan — the large patriarchal family of several generations under one roof.

gomasenyak — the raised winter room inside the cattle barn.

hampa — a haymaking team formed by kinship.

Javakhk — the Armenian name of the Javakheti plateau, around Akhalkalaki and Ninotsminda in Georgia.

Karin — the Armenian name of Erzurum and its plain.

kin quarter — a group of joined houses where one clan lived together.

mahla, mayla — a village quarter, named after the clan's eldest; *veri mayla* the upper, *tsatsi mayla* the lower half.

metrical book — a parish register of baptisms, marriages and burials.

nahapet — patriarch, the head of a whole family line.

tagh — the old Armenian word for a quarter, already forgotten in Karin.

tanuter, tantikin — master and mistress of the house.

tohm — a lineage or house descended in the male line from one ancestor.

tohmanun — the name of a *tohm*, taken from its founder; Bdoyan began as one (Afterword).

tohmatsar — family tree.

uyezd — a district of the Russian Empire, such as the Akhalkalaki uyezd.

-yan — the surname ending "of"; Bdoyan, "of Bdo's family".

yot port — "seven navels", the seven generations one was expected to know.

Reference NAMES IN THREE SCRIPTS

Names in Three Scripts

Records name the family and its places in Armenian, Russian and Georgian. Search for every form; Russian and Georgian place names are given in their modern forms. The Armenian-script forms are listed in the Armenian edition.

ENGLISH	RUSSIAN	GEORGIAN	OTHER FORMS
Bdoyan	Бдоян	ბდოიანი	Bdojan, Bdoian
Bdo · Bedros · Petros	Бдо · Петрос	პეტროსი	Western: Bedros
Pokr Khanchali	Патара-Ханчали	პატარა ხანჩალი	Patara Khanchali; Khanchalli
Mets Khanchali	Диди-Ханчали	დიდი ხანჩალი	Didi Khanchali
Abul	Абули	აბული	Abuli
Akhalkalaki	Ахалкалаки	ახალქალაქი	Akhalkalak
Ninotsminda	Ниноцминда	ნინოწმინდა	formerly Bogdanovka, Богдановка
Karin · Erzurum	Эрзурум	ერზურუმი	Theodosiopolis (ancient)
Dinarigom	—	—	Dinargom; today Myratgeldi, as given by Karapetian
Umudum	—	—	Umutum

Reference NOTES TO THE CHAPTERS

Notes

Short titles are given in full under Sources. Page numbers follow the editions listed there; "Bdoyan" means his *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk* (2014).

I · BDO OF THE KARIN PLAIN

1. The form "Bdoyents" is used in Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 91, 575, 730.
2. Wikipedia, "Monastery of Saint Minas of Kes", on the Armenian villages of the Erzurum plain before 1829.
3. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 530 and note 1.
4. *Soviet Armenian Encyclopedia*, vol. 5, "Karin" (district).
5. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 683, 730.
6. Acharyan, *Dictionary of Armenian Personal Names*, vol. 4, entry "Petros".
7. Armenian Historical Grammar project, "Classical Armenian phonology" (Western *Petros* [bedros]); Armenian Wikipedia, "Karno barbar". Vard Bdoyan's dialect texts from Javakhk use the Western present "kə tesni", "he sees": Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 414.
8. Houshamadyan, "Bedoyan Collection — Athens and Nea Erythraia".
9. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 150; summarised by R. Gharibyan, ibid., 21.
10. On the Armenian great family: Nahapetyan, "A Great Benefactor", summarising Vard Bdoyan's work; Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 161–186.
11. Nahapetyan, "A Great Benefactor"; Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 148–153.
12. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 707 (note to the legend of the Khachapayt spring).
13. Ibid., 183, 201.
14. General description after Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, chapters on farming, herding and dwellings.

II · THE GREAT EXODUS

1. Wikipedia, "Monastery of Saint Minas of Kes" (about 10,000 families, 75,000 people); Armenian Wikipedia, "Javakhk" (about 80,000).
2. Melkonyan, *Javakhk*, 14–15.
3. Melkonyan, *Javakhk*, 14 (Akhalkalaki and Khertvisi, July 1828).
4. Melkonyan, *Javakhk*, 14.
5. Melkonyan, *Javakhk*, 14–15, and note 2 to the documents (Bagratuni's dates).
6. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 140.
7. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 18–20.
8. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 29–30 (Abul; Umudum), 360 (Majadia), 375 (Mets Khanchali), 530 (Pokr Khanchali).
9. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 148; our translation.
10. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 530.
11. Wikipedia, "Karin dialect" (spoken today in Shirak and in Akhalkalaki, Akhaltsikhe and Ninotsminda).
12. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 29 (Abul), 42 (Alatuman), 126 (Burnashet), 304 (Korkh), 308 (Kulikam), 360 (Majadia), 375 (Mets Khanchali), 527 (Pokr Gyondura), 530 (Pokr Khanchali).

III · A NEW HOME ON LAKE KHANCHALI

1. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 530, citing *Sbornik materialov dlya opisaniya Tiflisskoy gubernii* (1870), 32; *Ardzagank* 1885, no. 3, 41; and N. Berdzenishvili.
2. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 530; Armenian Wikipedia, "Pokr Khanchali" (2014 census).
3. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 150.
4. Ibid., 151–152 (houses 28–32).
5. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 91–92.
6. Ibid., 730 (note to the song "Qambakh ellin dzer jaghchnin"); the song itself, 575.
7. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 530–531, from the files of fond 53 of the National Archives of Armenia; another source gives 608 for 1914 (*Kavkazskiy kalendar na 1915 god*, 195).
8. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 29, 531; Melkonyan, *Javakhk*, 24–49.

9. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 683.
10. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 531, citing A. Davtyan, *Javakhk* (1994), 101, and the village council registers.
11. Armenian Wikipedia, "Pokr Khanchali".
12. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 531; Armenian Apostolic Church in Georgia, "Pokr Khanchali – Surb Hakob church".
13. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 531.
14. Ibid., 531, citing fond 53, file 3848, and S. Khudoyan, *Eastern Armenian Schools*, 518.
15. Armenian texts in Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 531–532; translations ours.
16. Armenian Apostolic Church in Georgia, "Pokr Khanchali – Surb Hakob church".
17. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 531; Armenian Apostolic Church in Georgia, ibid.
18. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 532.
19. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 17–19.
20. Wikipedia, "Akhalkalaki uezd".
21. Gharibyan, preface to Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 21.
22. "Karno (Javakhk) dialect", student project, 2021.
23. Wikipedia, "Karin dialect"; Armenian Wikipedia, "Karno barbar".

IV · VARD BDOYAN, THE FAMILY'S SCHOLAR

1. Figures in the strip above: Nahapetyan, "A Great Benefactor"; Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 747.
2. Nahapetyan, "A Great Benefactor".
3. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 747.
4. Career: Nahapetyan, "A Great Benefactor". Doctorate (1970) and death: Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 747; Armenian Wikipedia, "Vard Bdoyan".
5. Nahapetyan, "A Great Benefactor".
6. Quotations on dress, kinship words, the village and "disguise": Nahapetyan, "A Great Benefactor", with the Armenian original of the first quotation. On resettling: Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 148. Translations ours.
7. Nahapetyan, "A Great Benefactor".
8. Gharibyan, preface to Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 6–7.
9. Ibid., title page verso (p. 2) and 7.
10. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 707, 711, 720, 683.
11. Gharibyan, preface, ibid., 8.
12. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 707 (Varvare), 151 (house 28), 747 (Vard, son of Harutyun).
13. Ibid., 683.

V · ONE ANCESTOR, ONE FAMILY

1. Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 530; family tradition.
2. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 151–152, 730.
3. Gharibyan, preface to Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 21.
4. Surname-distribution estimate, surnam.es, "Bdoyan surname" (see Chapter VII).
5. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 720, 732, 734; Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 29 (Umudum, 16 km north of Karin).

VI · THE BDOYANS WE KNOW

1. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 8, 150–152, 683, 707–738.

VII · WHERE THE BDOYANS LIVE TODAY

1. surnam.es, "Bdoyan surname". The figures are modelled estimates, not a census; they are given to show proportions only.
2. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 707 (Gevorg), 711 (Khachatur), 720 (Balasan; Ruben and Sirun), 747 (Vard).
3. General pattern of migration from Javakhk: Melkonyan, *Javakhk*; Karapetian, *Javakhk*, 18–22. Not specific to the Bdoyans.

AFTERWORD · HOW THIS HISTORY COULD BE WRITTEN

1. On the clan (*azg*, *tohm*) and the house named after its eldest: Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 148–152; Gharibyan, preface, ibid., 21.
2. See Chapter III, "The surname becomes official".
3. surnam.es, "Bdoyan surname" (modelled estimate; see Chapter VII).
4. Bdoyan, *Ethnography and Folk Art of Javakhk*, 148–152 (village plan), 730 (Papo's mill), 707–738 (storytellers).

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FAMILY AND MAPS

Family tradition, as given by the Bdoyan family for this booklet: Bdo as founder, his house in Dinarigom, and the descent of all Bdoyans from him.

Map data: Natural Earth (public domain), 1:10m and 1:50m cultural and physical vectors. Historical frontier, routes and family centres drawn for this booklet; the small lakes of Javakheti are shown schematically.

A NOTE ON CERTAINTY

Confirmed by records: Pokr Khanchali's settlement from Dinarigom in 1829–1830; Bdoyents Papo and his mill; the five Bdoyan houses of the 1910s; the Abul line from Hakob Bdoyan of Umudum; Vard Bdoyan's life and work; the church history; the archive references. *Family tradition:* Bdo himself, his house in Dinarigom, and the descent of every Bdoyan, the Abul line included, from him. *Estimates:* Bdo's baptismal name (probably Bedros, that is Petros), his dates, generation counts, Papo's generation, Varvare as Vard's mother, the likely centres on the maps. All can be tested against the records in the research handbook.

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THE HOUSE BDOYAN

In 1829 the families of Dinarigom, a village on the high plain of Karin, packed their carts and followed the Russian army north across a new frontier. On the shore of Lake Khanchali they rebuilt their village — and one household, known as “Bdo’s people”, became the Bdoyans.

This book follows them from Bdo (Bedros), head of a great Karin household, through Bdoyents Papo and his mill, the five Bdoyan houses of the 1910s and the ethnographer Vard Bdoyan, to the 1,400 Bdoyans of today — with every fact tied to its source.



Companion volume: Finding the Bdoyans — A Research Handbook
Online edition and contributions: claude.ai/artifact/FcnSZy3zKiXexgTckt51aL
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Front cover photograph: Yasuhiro Kojima, CC BY-SA 4.0